a true story

You don't need a SaaS to track competitors.

I wrote a cron job instead.

swipe →

the question

What does it take to know when a competitor *changes pricing*?

Strip it down and it's four jobs:

Watch
the pages that matter: pricing, product, changelog

Notice
when something real changes, not a timestamp

Explain
what it means for your pitch

Update
the battlecard before the next deal

none of these needs a server running all day.

the method

Code watches. *AI reads* only what changed.

1. **Cron, once a week**
   GitHub Actions in your private repo
2. **Fetch & clean** — free
   robots.txt first; strip timestamps and noise
3. **Diff & filter** — free
   vs last week; keyword triggers; size threshold
4. **AI triage** — capped
   fast model: noise, minor or material
5. **AI analysis** — capped
   stronger model, material changes only
6. **Digest + battlecards**
   committed to your repo; issue, Slack or Discord

the numbers

What the *first runs* showed

211

passing tests before the first real website

8

real pages across 4 example competitors

0

AI calls on the second run: nothing changed

$0

spent on that run

The expensive run is the first: 4 battlecards ≈ **$0.10–0.25** on Claude Opus. estimate

the boring run is the whole argument.

the limits

Real websites broke *3 assumptions*

Examples, not a review of these companies.

Convin wrong site

From my server, it redirected to a US product for home-service businesses.

Hyperbound likely A/B test

`/pricing` quietly redirected to `/pricing-b`.

Second Nature 208 chars

Came back almost empty until one `include` selector pulled in 4.7k characters.

and: no real competitor change caught yet.

the insight

The AI was the easy part. *The plumbing* was the product.

the battlecard said

“Don’t lead with ‘we support Hindi’.”

Hyperbound already lists Hindi, Gujarati, Marathi and Tamil.

what actually broke

- a request format the API rejects
- an npm install that deleted the engine
- Docker reading a comment as the key
- alerts that could ping a Slack channel

None of them was the model. All of them are fixed.

the rule

Before you trust *any AI tool*

- [x] **Run it on three real sites** before you trust it.
- [x] **Read what it extracted, not what it concluded.** A 208-character page still gets a confident summary.
- [x] **Run it twice.** If the second run isn't quiet, your noise filtering is wrong.
- [x] **Check the final URL.** Geo redirects and A/B tests are real.
- [x] **Filter before you call a model.** Keywords and size thresholds are free.
- [x] **Cap the cost of every run.**

Rule of thumb: if the pages change *weekly or slower*, a cron job beats a subscription.

the takeaway

Competitor tracking *can be* a cron job.

Outflank is free and open source.

Template + repo link in the first comment. Want something like this built for your team? Message me.

your turn

What would you watch first: pricing pages, changelogs or careers pages?